

Example #1 - Deferred ED, then Accepted to Wharton RD

I would like to begin by thanking the admissions committee for offering me the opportunity to be considered to attend the University. While many things have changed since I first sent my application, the most important aspect of it remains the same: my top-choice school is still the University, in particular, the School of Business.

In December, I graduated high school and received my IB exam results, which totaled XX out of 45 points. Though I was slightly disappointed with some of the grades I received, I know I did my best and worked very hard. Now, I am using what I learned through my IB and college application experience to help younger students at my high school in their respective journeys. I aim to continue tutoring these students after I move to attend college, too.

Given my senior year performance, my high school awarded me five certificates: one for outstanding performance in Biology; one for excellent academic performance in Biology, Portuguese, and Spanish, respectively; and a fifth one for effort in History, for which I felt especially proud since I was not expecting that many certificates because each of them can only be given to one student per grade.

After graduating in December, I finished my other college applications and my holidays began. My TV show hiatus finally came to an end! I could catch up on all of the shows I had on hold and even discovered a new interest: documentaries about sea life. Although my TV habit may seem superficial, I would like to highlight that I am still learning! I have watched TV shows in Portuguese, English, Spanish, and even Italian, which has helped me further practice my language skills. I have also learned that 1) contrary to popular thought, Klaus Mikaelson is indeed destructible, 2) Lucifer Morningstar always wins (no matter what), and 3) Shonda Rhimes never ceases to surprise me.

Beginning in February, I will be interning with TheSound, the National record label, which is strongly related to what I plan for my future career: working in the entertainment industry. At TheSound, I'll learn about the marketing strategies behind a song or an artist and the way music and its marketing can influence a specific public. Moreover, the experience I will gain in the music business field will help me feel more prepared for college and life thereafter. I will witness first-hand how the industry works and will be able to share my own experience with my peers.

Outside of my internship, I will be taking a Japanese language course to improve my Japanese speaking, reading, and writing skills. I also aim to focus on my physical and mental health through different activities, such as sports and meditation. Regular exercise and meditation is something I sacrificed during the chaotic examination period that preceded my high school graduation. Reinstating such practice is important to me, and I know it will best serve me as I prepare for university.

It has sadly come to my attention that Professor Professor passed away late last year. My condolences. I was preparing to contact him and discuss my interest in the influence of images and visual culture, but I know there are equally excellent professors at the University I can work with to explore the social challenges involved in marketing and advertising.

I would like to thank you once again for your consideration and state that I will gladly enroll in the School of Business if offered a position in the class of 2023. I hope I am offered this opportunity and am able to benefit from professors and their mentorship, take advantage of the clubs and fellowships available, cheer on the Mascots, and become a part of this unique community.

Example #2 - Deferred REA to Harvard (Ultimately accepted RD to Yale)

Dear Dean William R. Fitzsimmons,

Thank you for continuing to consider me for admission to the Class of 2023. I still wholeheartedly believe Harvard is an excellent fit for me. I know that there are many strong applicants in the Regular Decision round so I would like to use this letter as an opportunity to showcase why I am right for Harvard.

I visited campus in October 2018 and I was able to better understand Harvard's extensive academic, professional, and extracurricular offerings and how I could positively impact the Harvard community. Since my visit, I have remained in contact with Professor Steven Levitsky in the Department of Government and Dr. Michael Bronski, the Professor of Practice in the Media and Activism, to learn more about the topics covered during my stay such as the Kinsey Reports and how different governments derive their power. I have also stayed in touch with my wonderful host, Larry Dang '22, and his suitemates Senator Atwater '22 and Nick Maxwell '22.

I intend to take full advantage of the Government program at Harvard, as my experiences interning for Congresswoman Susan Davis, working at The Barrio Impact, and interning at the Bilateral Safety Corridor Coalition have established a foundation for me to build upon to be an effective force for positive change. At Harvard, I would like to be involved with the Institute of Politics, the Phillips Brooks House Association, and the Harvard Political Review. Being an active member of my community is something I've always valued, especially as the captain of my school's Quiz Bowl team and founder of the College Awareness Club, so I see myself trying new things like joining OnHarvardTime and The Harvard Lampoon.

I have not slowed down since submitting my application as I will graduate as salutatorian and I have remained politically active in the San Diego area. I was recently selected by the mayor of Chula Vista, Mary Salas, to be mentored one-on-one for my senior capstone project where I will explore my interest in government at the local level. If accepted, I intend to translate my political skills into a run for the Undergraduate Council and possibly even for Cambridge City Council. I would love to speak with Nadya Okamoto '20 about her campaign and what she felt she could have done differently. The combination of those activities and my studies at Harvard would leave me better equipped to pursue a dual JD/MBA, practice law, and then possibly hold elected office.

Again, thank you for taking more time to evaluate my application, I am grateful for this second chance. If necessary, I would be more than happy to be interviewed again or to answer more questions. Harvard remains my first-choice school, and if I am selected for admission, I will most certainly attend.

Sincerely,

Additional Examples

Example 1

Dear Admissions Office,

After applying, the more I researched and spoke to the student body via online forums and alumni from my high school, the more convinced I became that the University of Michigan is undoubtedly my first choice. I would like to reaffirm that I will most certainly be attending your university, should I be privileged enough to be

admitted, by detailing the plans that will allow me to make the very most of this opportunity.

As I converse with my friends at UMich, such as Yongjing Ren (Class of 2021) about student life at UMich, I become all the more convinced that this is where I'd like to call home for the next four years, and beyond. Her description of her experiences living in the residence halls has elaborated on my understanding of the student culture in Ann Arbor; its apparent friendliness and emphasis on work-life balance continues to appeal to me. She also noted that Michigan's innovative and service-oriented culture means it's easy for students to initiate projects at the university, such as establishing new clubs. I find this prospect particularly exciting, as I founded and co-led the Tibetan Dance Group during high school when I realized the importance of peaceful Tibetan-Chinese relations after learning about the realities of Tibet's political situation and the harm of our previous prejudices. I also intend to continue my passion for this cause, by participating in the Tibet Initiative, whose aim is uncannily parallel to that of my Cultural Group. Similarly, I also intend to extend myself in initiatives I've yet to explore- like the Tibetan Buddhist Studies program at the LSA- or even starting up my own initiative on campus!

Although I graduated from high school and returned to Shanghai for my 'summer break', my break thus far has been productive and meaningful. As a fan of architecture, and to prepare for the second year of the NZss Future Competition - the first New Zealand architecture competition for high-schoolers my friend and I initiated last year - as a co-leader, I began exploring The Architectural Imagination by Harvard on edX. The lectures given by Professor K. Michael Hay have helped me better understand ways to express different societies' deepest social values through architecture, and served as inspiration for 'library' as a theme option for the competition. Since then, I've been pondering ways to incorporate aspects of my own culture into design, as a means of better understanding it, and continuing its preservation. These thoughts also led me to undertake an internship at the Xihan Action project in China, which targets the declining production of traditional Chinese handmade artwork originating from diverse ethnic groups and regions. By linking these works to aspects of contemporary culture, such as celebrity figures and popular soaps, we revive and preserve historical art through social media to appeal to a wide demographic. In doing so, I learnt to appeal to certain age groups via various mediums of communication and writing styles. I also developed an understanding of how frequently to publish announcements, and how to modify their tone to maximise audience engagement. As part of the project, we also provide links for those who are interested in learning these art skills, which allows us to quantitatively monitor engagement via the number of 'clicks.' Through this, we can gauge which approaches to communication are successful, hence informing my own studies in this area.

Yongjing Ren also mentioned to me sports plays a huge part of student life at Michigan - something I'm eager to delve into. What attracts me the most is that sports clubs at UMich are non-exclusive - meaning that while extremely competitive, they also provide recreational opportunities for students of diverse ability levels to promote healthy lifestyles. Knowing this, as a non-competitive runner, I feel more comfortable joining MRun, as well as trying out new sports, such as boxing. Additionally, I was further enticed by Yongjing mentioning the social aspect of cheering for the Wolverines. Besides being able to easily befriend others in clubs and at events, I'd also feel more broadly connected to the school itself, and the pride associated with being a student at Michigan. The sense of school spirit and community is one that I have heard to be prominent both during students' times at UMich and beyond, and I'd love to be part of this.

All such qualities cement Michigan's position as my first choice school. Although I'm aware that this letter may not have an impact on your team's reconsideration of my application, I believe it's important to give you an update on what I've been doing recently- and a reaffirmation that UMich still remains as my first-choice.

Kind Regards,

EXAMPLE 2

Dear Stanford Admission Officer,

Since graduating, I've focused on self-exploration, seeking to deepen core interests but also forage in new areas.

I have a new fascination with extreme sport. I confess, much to the sadness of the critics on Rotten Tomato, that I was triggered by the action movie xXx, featuring Vin Diesel. The airborne scenes in xXx made me realize that I've literally never felt an airborne sensation except flying so I changed that! On January 14th, I bungy jumped at the Nevis bungy in Queenstown, New Zealand, which has a record-breaking 134m drop. The only thing worse than wind howling against your body overlooking a gaping canyon is realizing you have to jump into it! Paradoxically, I loved it. I was falling so fast in fact that if I were to equate KE with GPE, estimating the equilibrium position of the rope at half the height, I would have flown at an astounding 130km/h!

I also enrolled in a rock climbing gym called "Climb Fit". Funnily enough, I predominantly climb with Physic Club mates. We aren't the usual climbers with our constant physics jokes but we are a community. I can't wait to further my climbing at the Stanford Climbing Wall which seems to have the most Yelp reviews of any climbing wall I've ever seen!

My fascination with artificial intelligence has grown since the victory of AlphaGo as I plot Australia wide expansion of MCQuizzKnox and our Android rollout. As I read about growth hacks to amplify app downloads, I was surprised to find how many companies pay Facebook heavily to drive app downloads. I discovered how intensively Facebook's advertising platform uses data science and machine learning. I'd love to understand how these kind of algorithms work theoretically but also be able to think through applications into new businesses. As I continue to broaden my understanding of data science, I come across more and more Stanford inspired coursework with innovative partners like Coursera and practical Data Science Master's degrees. While I've only started with Statistical Reasoning on Stanford's online platform, I get excited about developing these interests as a Stanford student alongside challenging peers. The number of Stanford recruits getting hired in high stakes positions at Facebook and Snapchat is electrifying.

I've also been running HSC seminars on Maths and Physics at Knox. Last year, I found these seminars helpful but there was a real need to improve them for the next wave of the Knox "Tartan" army.

While I care about Knox, the challenges students face are more profound in China. My sister and I started an organization called LEAFA (Learning and Education Available For All). In December, we collected 1500 books from Knox families, Aussie libraries and garage sales (bargain hunting the 50 cent copies) to be shipped to my mum's rural middle school called Jinshan ZhongXue. We hope our humble start will be a powerful tool for educational empowerment in this community.

I've taken concrete action to fight against air pollution in China by volunteering as a photographer for The Nature Conservancy. While statistics are crucial, vivid images, which translates the toxic environment many Chinese citizens struggle with everyday, are powerful tools in soliciting donations in the West.

Stanford has inspired environmental conservationists like Professor Gretchen Daily to practical design-centred engineering masterminds like Evan Spiegel. I am thrilled by the university's interest in my candidacy and I hope to develop my sprawling passions within a community of gifted quantitative minds, social entrepreneurs and changemakers.

Yours Sincerely,

EXAMPLE 3

Dear Admissions Officers at Columbia University,

There was a red velvet cake. A cake, in my opinion, that embodies the spirit of Columbia University.

As the cake was carried to Carman Hall, Mike, the public safety officer that sat at the front desk, did not anticipate the surprise that was to come. In appreciation for all the work that Mike did, a group of 20 or so students gathered in the dorm to surprise him. The words "Stay Awesome" were spelled out in red frosting, the cake was cut, and the work that the Mike did, and still does, at Columbia was appreciated.

It is the little moments that define the liveliness of Columbia's campus. I heard this story, and could easily see the student body as a caring, passionate, group of people who truly appreciate each individual --- a rare attribute in New York City where time is too precious to give up. Individuals are valued not just by how well they do their job or schoolwork, but how they impact others around them. Columbia truly does "stay awesome."

I know that I want to be part of this community above all else.

As you know, in December I learned that my Early Decision application to Columbia University had been deferred. As you can imagine, this news was disappointing, as Columbia remains at the top of my list of prospective colleges for the Class of 2020. I wanted to thank you and your colleagues for taking the time to consider my application, and fill you in on some new information regarding my candidacy.

As the new winter term at Deerfield Academy has begun, I'm excited to continue my work in visual arts. In my work as the layout editor at Albany Road, Deerfield's Literary and Arts Magazine, my layout team has had the honor of designing the broadside for visiting Poet Laureate Rita Dove.

In addition, I had the privilege of participating in a lunch with Rita Dove to discuss her writing process and career as a poet. In addition, I am currently launching an initiative at school to help local Franklin County shelters and encourage female students to donate their sanitary products at the end of the year as we move out of our dorms. Our frustration towards the price of sanitary products, given that they are a necessity in our lives, is an issue that is not lost on us. As Deerfield is located in Franklin County, the third poorest county in Massachusetts, I thought it was appropriate to begin action on this initiative and contribute to local women in need. Although the project has just started, I am excited to work as one of the board members of the Center for Service and Global Citizenship to initiate this ambition.

I would be ecstatic to join Columbia's class of 2020 and embrace all that is Columbia. From throwing glow stick rings on Alma Mater's statue to studying at Butler until 3 AM, my preference for Columbiaremains unchanged. If I were fortunate enough to receive an offer, I would accept it immediately, and take the chance to contribute to the Columbiacommunity and make it a place that I will call home.

Please also see an attached additional peer reference written for me by Rachel V____, a senior student at Deerfield Academy, who I hope can shed some additional light on who I am as a person beyond my application. In addition, I have attached a few sketches of Columbia's campus I have finished in the past few weeks and my recent winter midterm grades.

Stay Awesome, and Respectfully Submitted,

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